

Handout: *Robin Collins – A Scientific Argument for the Existence of God*

I. The Problem and Proposed Solution

Collins begins from a striking empirical and philosophical problem:

- **Problem:**

The universe appears “**fine-tuned**” for life—its fundamental constants and initial conditions fall within extremely narrow ranges that permit the existence of complex, intelligent beings.

- Even minute deviations (e.g., gravitational strength, nuclear forces) would render life impossible (pp. 211–212).
- This raises a **cosmological explanatory gap**:
Why does the universe have life-permitting structure rather than not?

- **Solution (Thesis):**

Collins argues that **fine-tuning constitutes strong evidence for theism**, because:

- Fine-tuning is **much more probable under theism** than under atheism.
- Therefore, by a general principle of probabilistic reasoning, it **confirms theism over its rivals**.

Importantly, Collins does **not claim proof**, but rather **comparative confirmation**—a key move in contemporary philosophy of religion.

II. The Empirical Basis: Fine-Tuning

A. What is Fine-Tuning?

- The universe’s **laws, constants, and initial conditions** are “balanced on a razor’s edge” for life (p. 211).
- Examples:
 - Big Bang expansion rate must be precise to **1 part in 10^{60}**
 - Strong nuclear force must be within ~5%
 - Gravity fine-tuned to **1 part in 10^{40}**

B. Analogies

Collins uses vivid analogies to convey improbability:

- **“Radio dials” analogy:** all parameters must be set exactly right
- **“Cosmic dartboard”:** life-permitting region is a tiny target

These analogies function epistemically: they **translate abstract probability into intuitive judgment**.

III. The Core Argument (Single-Universe Case)

A. The Prime Principle of Confirmation

Key epistemic principle:

An observation counts as evidence for hypothesis H_1 over H_2 if it is more probable under H_1 than H_2 (p. 213).

- This is a **Bayesian-style confirmation principle**
 - Widely used in:
 - Science
 - Legal reasoning (e.g., fingerprints)
 - Everyday inference
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B. Formal Argument

- **Premise 1:** Fine-tuning is **not improbable under theism**
 - **Premise 2:** Fine-tuning is **very improbable under atheistic single-universe hypothesis**
 - **Conclusion:**
→ Fine-tuning **strongly confirms theism over atheism**
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C. Clarifications

- The argument is:
 - **Comparative**, not absolute
 - **Evidential**, not deductive

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- Analogy: fingerprints → evidence of guilt, not proof
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IV. Support for the Premises

A. Premise (1): Fine-Tuning Fits Theism

- If God is **omnibenevolent**, it is not surprising that:
 - God would create **intelligent life**
 - Thus, fine-tuning is **expected under theism**
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B. Premise (2): Fine-Tuning is Improbable Under Atheism

- Atheistic single-universe hypothesis:
 - Universe is a “**brute fact**”
 - Given random parameter assignment:
 - Life-permitting range is **extremely small**
 - Supported by:
 - **Principle of indifference** (Appendix)
 - Probability ratios of parameter ranges
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V. Objections and Replies (Core Argument)

1. More Fundamental Law Objection

- Claim: constants must have these values due to deeper laws
 - Reply:
 - This **shifts the improbability up one level**
 - Why that law?
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2. “Other Forms of Life” Objection

- Claim: life could exist under different conditions
- Reply:
 - Argument only assumes **minimal complexity requirements**

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- Not anthropocentric
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3. Anthropic Principle Objection

- Claim: we observe fine-tuning because we exist
 - Reply:
 - This does not explain **why we exist**
 - Analogy: **firing squad misses** → demands explanation
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4. “Who Designed God?” Objection

- Claim: God would also require explanation
 - Reply:
 - Argument only requires **greater probability**, not ultimate explanation
 - Even a complex designer can still be **better explanation than chance**
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VI. The Many-Universes Hypothesis

A. The Alternative

- Atheists propose:
 - **Multiverse generator** producing many universes
 - Random variation → some life-permitting universes
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B. Collins' Critique

1. Lack of Independent Evidence

- Not a natural extrapolation from experience
- Theism is (via mind-based design analogies)

2. Fine-Tuning of the Generator

- Multiverse mechanism itself appears **fine-tuned**

3. Problem of Laws

- Must explain:
 - Why **these laws of physics**?

4. Aesthetic Features

- Laws exhibit:
 - **Elegance, beauty, mathematical harmony**
- Better explained by **intelligence**

5. Entropy Problem

- Universe began in **highly ordered state**
 - Multiverse predicts only **local order**, not global order
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VII. Final Comparative Claim

Collins concludes with an interesting meta-argument:

- Fine-tuning argument vs. **argument from evil**
 - Atheist argument depends on **uncertain probability judgments**
 - Fine-tuning relies on:
 - **quantifiable physics**
 - **objective probability reasoning**

Therefore:

The fine-tuning argument provides **stronger evidence for theism** than the argument from evil does for atheism (pp. 220–221).

VIII. Appendix: Probability and Fine-Tuning

A. Principle of Indifference

- Assign equal probability to **equipossible alternatives**
- In continuous cases:
 - Probability = **ratio of ranges**

B. Application

- Life-permitting values are:
 - **Tiny subset** of possible values
 - Therefore:
 - Fine-tuning is **highly improbable under atheism**
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C. Two Interpretations of Probability

1. **Classical probability**
 - Ratio of favorable cases to total cases
 2. **Epistemic probability**
 - Rational degree of belief
 - Key for **confirmation theory**
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